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Daily Life in Korea for Foreigners

ARC registration, trash sorting, cost of living, convenience store culture, Korean workplace etiquette and everything in between.



Alien Registration Card (ARC)

The ARC (외국인등록증, Alien Registration Card) is your most important document in Korea. Without it, you can't open a bank account, get a phone plan, or sign up for health insurance.

ARC — Everything You Need to Know

WHO NEEDS IT

- Foreigners staying 90+ days
- Anyone on a work or student visa
- Working holiday visa holders

WHAT TO BRING

- Passport + visa
- Passport-size photo (3.5×4.5cm)
- Completed application form
- ₩30,000 fee

1

Find your nearest Immigration Office

Search 출입국관리사무소 on Naver Maps. Major offices: Seoul (Seoul Station, Mapo), Incheon, Busan, Daegu. Some larger community centers (주민센터) also process applications.

2

Apply within 90 days of arrival

You must register within 90 days of entering Korea (or within 90 days of your visa start date). Late registration results in a fine up to ₩200,000.

3

Wait 2–3 weeks

Processing takes 2–3 weeks. You can check status online at hi.korea.go.kr. The card is mailed to your Korean address or can be picked up at the immigration office.

4

Carry it at all times

Technically required to carry your ARC (or passport) at all times in Korea. Police rarely check, but you'll need it for hospitals, banks, phone stores and more.



Trash Sorting in Korea

Korea has mandatory trash sorting — violations can result in fines. The system takes a few days to learn but becomes routine quickly.



Food Waste (음식물)

Yellow designated bags. Sold at convenience stores. Weighed by volume — you pay per bag used.



Recyclables (재활용)

Paper, plastic, cans, bottles — separated. Put in the colored bins by your building or on the street on designated days.



General Waste (일반 쓰레기)

Non-recyclable trash only. Must use official designated garbage bags (종량제봉투) — sold at GS25, CU etc.



Large Items (대형폐기물)

Furniture, appliances — require a special sticker purchased at the local community center (주민센터) before disposal.



Glass (유리)

Separate from other recyclables. Bottles are sorted by color in some areas. Check your building's rules.



Trash day: Most buildings have designated trash days or areas. Ask your landlord or building manager (관리인) which days to put out which types. Getting this wrong is the most common foreigner mistake.



Convenience Store Life

Korean convenience stores (편의점) — GS25, CU, 7-Eleven, Emart24 — are remarkable. They're open 24/7 and serve as a one-stop shop for daily life.

WHAT YOU CAN DO AT A CONVENIENCE STORE

- **Eat:** Fresh kimbap, triangular 삼각김밥, hot dogs, ramen cooked in-store (they have hot water dispensers and microwaves)
- **Bank:** ATM that accepts foreign cards, T-money top-up, pay utility bills, receive packages
- **Shop:** Toiletries, medicine, snacks, alcohol (until 11pm in some areas), phone chargers, stationery
- **Print:** Many convenience stores have multifunction printers — scan, print, copy documents
- **Send packages:** CJ LogisTown, GS Postbox — ship packages domestically for ₩3,000–6,000
- **Pay for tickets:** Concert tickets, transportation passes, online order pickups



Realistic Monthly Budget (Seoul)

CATEGORY	BUDGET LIVING	MID-RANGE	COMFORTABLE
Housing (rent + utilities)	₩450,000	₩900,000	₩1,500,000
Food (cooking + eating out)	₩250,000	₩450,000	₩700,000
Transport	₩60,000	₩80,000	₩120,000
Phone plan	₩15,000	₩45,000	₩70,000
Health insurance	₩79,000	₩100,000	₩130,000
Personal care / misc	₩80,000	₩150,000	₩250,000
Entertainment / dining out	₩100,000	₩200,000	₩400,000
Total / month	~₩1.0M	~₩1.9M	~₩3.2M



Korean Culture & Etiquette

✓ Do

- Use two hands when giving/receiving items
- Remove shoes when entering homes
- Pour drinks for others before yourself
- Say 잘 먹겠습니다 before eating
- Address elders and seniors respectfully
- Bow slightly when greeting someone older
- Stand on the right side of escalators

✗ Don't

- Write someone's name in red ink (associated with death)
- Tip at restaurants — it can be awkward
- Talk loudly on the phone on the subway
- Blow your nose at the table
- Sit in priority seating (노약자석)
- Pass food chopstick-to-chopstick

- Be quiet on public transport

- Leave chopsticks standing upright in rice
- Start eating before the eldest person at the table

Korean Workplace Culture

WHAT TO EXPECT

- **Hierarchy matters:** Address superiors formally — use their title (부장님, 팀장님) not their name
- **Working hours:** Official hours may be 9–6, but staying late (눈치 — reading the room) is common in traditional companies
- **회식 (Hoesik):** Team dinner/drinking events are semi-compulsory in many workplaces — important for bonding
- **Business cards:** Receive with two hands, read it, don't write on it or stuff it in your pocket immediately
- **Age:** Koreans often ask your age early — it determines how they speak to you and the relationship dynamic
- **Startup vs. conglomerate:** Startups and international companies are much more relaxed than traditional Korean chaebols (삼성, LG, Hyundai etc.)

Everyday Korean Phrases

잘 부탁드립니다.	<i>jal bu-tak-deu-rim-ni-da.</i>	I look forward to working with you.
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수고하셨습니다.	<i>su-go-ha-syeoss-eum-ni-da.</i>	Good work / You've worked hard.
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잘 먹겠습니다.	<i>jal meok-gess-eum-ni-da.</i>	I'll eat well. (said before eating)
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잘 먹었습니다.	<i>jal meok-eoss-eum-ni-da.</i>	I ate well. (said after eating)
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쓰레기봉투 어디서 사요?	<i>sseu-re-gi-bong-tu eo-di-seo sa-yo?</i>	Where do I buy trash bags?
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주민센터가 어디예요?	<i>ju-min-sen-teo-ga eo-di-ye-yo?</i>	Where is the community center?
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